

Oscar Wilde - Dorian Gray

Extract

First it is Lord Henry who is talking

Aphorism → Beauty is a form of Genius → then other aphorisms → it is only shallow people...

Time is jealous of you → personification of time → his youth is compared to flowers, metaphors → also gold of your days

Lord Henry's philosophy of life is a new hedonism → the purpose of life is to follow pleasure only, and ignore morality and social rules

Henry says to Dorian that he is lucky to be young and handsome, but this will not be for ever → and he will be miserable, so he has to live his age fully

There is a dark prophecy → he will stab the painting and will die because of this

Dorian will exhibit the picture in his living room, but as he notices some changes in the picture, he moves it to his attic

Last statement is his fatal wish

Gothic element → something irrational dreadful happens

The night when Dorian dies, Dorian decides to live a different life → he wants to stop following pleasure → and after taking that decision, he climbs the stairs to the attic

He thinks that the portrait must have started changing → it has become a horrible old monstrous man → but the painting doesn't change, and a hypocritical sneer shows up → he didn't want to change really (maybe)

So he stabs the painting, and transforms in the hideous figure of the painting, while the painting returns to its original state

The servants recognize him only for his rings

British literature on WWI

The first world war is also called the great war → 1914 - 1918 → Italy joins in 1915
UK joins because:

- it needed to support its allies to Russia and France
- rivalry with Germany → it was a dangerous country because:
 - economical → UK was the richest and more industrialized country in the world → but Germany had become competition

- political →britain still had the most powerful colonial empire →but germany was building its empire in africa

The war started in 1914, until 1916 the british army was made only of volunteers →for two years, hundreds of thousands of young men decided to go to the front and fight for their country

Some of them did it out of patriotism, but most of them because they were convinced by pro-war propaganda

Pro-war propaganda worked through articles in newspapers and magazines →young people were invited to leave for the front in order not to look like cowards

There were sit-ins which were trying to convince young men to join the army →young men were stopped

They also gave those young men white feathers, symbol of cowardy →there was a lot of psychological pressure

There were also lots of posters →aim to convince young men to join the war

Britons want you

King of england is pointing to the reader →britons were a celtic population, that lived in england around 100 b.C. →they survived the roman invasion →in year 410 a.D. they regained independence from the roman empire, which ruled between 43 and 410 a.D.

450 a.D. anglosaxons attacked britain (a germanic population) →the populations migrated to wales →then anglosaxons and celtics started to merge

Propaganda did not want to consider the anglosaxons (germanic tribe) as the real ancestors of the english people →they wanted the celts, so they called britons

Take up the sword of justice

Personification of justice →it was honorable and just to join the war →young men had to fight for justice

Beat back the hun

Hun stands for "unni" →germans are compared to huns, that were a barbaric and violent tribe lead by Attila →germans are monsters and barbarians

It is a german soldier, painted as a monster and his hands dirty of blood of innocent people

Who's absent

A man wearing a ? with the uk flag →invites to enlist →and asks who is absent, not gone to the front

Father

Children ask their father what did he do during the WWI →plays on the sense of guilt

In 1916 volunteers were not enough, so all british men aged between 18 and 31 were obliged to enter the british army →conspiction was introduced

Even young men from the colonies tried to be involved

The empire needs men

Propaganda for men from the colonies →symbolism of the young lions (colonies) and old lions (uk)

In this propaganda symbolism is used a lot

Women of britain say work

Isnt all work

Men would have had recreational activities too →not only fighting

Soldiers in WWI did not spend most of their time fighting, but in trenches = terrible living conditions

When they fought, they were fighting against disruptive new war machines (not other soldiers)

They left with some expectations, but they found a completely different situation

Many suffered from PTSD →these soldiers are called shell-shock

”To go over the top” = to attack the nearest trench →”no man’s land” is the area separating two trenches

Maggio 13

PTSD = post traumatic stress disorder →this form was called ”shell-shocked”, and they are called ”shell-shocked soldiers” →and they were not treated

In case of severe shell-shock they were recovered in the ”Craiglockhart hospital” →they were sent here not in order to let them adjust to civilian life again, but to treat them to send them again to the front

Some survived and return to the UK as war veterans, who after the end of the great war had a hard time in adjusting to civilian life again

British women also played a central role in the british war efforts →they were not soldiers, but they contributed:

- by replacing men in factories
- by joining the propaganda system
- they were sent to the front as nurses →there is a lot of british literature of female authors that were nurses in WWI

After the great war women were rewarded by being granted the right to vote (in 1919)
→initially only women over 30 could vote, now over 18
War poets = professional poets who ended up in war

Two war poems

Both authors fought during the war, and reflected on their experience at the front in some of their poems

The soldier - Rupert Brooke

He was part of a poetical movement known as "georgians" → he is a "georgian poet" → they wrote their poems between 1910 and 1915, when George V was king of the UK

The georgians tended to write about the English countryside → they considered it as the essence of "Englishness" → influence of Wordsworth

Rupert Brooke wrote this before leaving for the front → he is enthusiastic and is a volunteer → he died some weeks later after writing this

This poem is an Italian sonnet → made of 14 lines, grouped into an octave and a sestet (the English sonnet is made of 3 quatrains and a couplet)

At the beginning of the 20th century started to write poems in free verses (no forms, no rhymes) → however Georgian poems were traditional

First line → assonance in "o" and alliteration in "d"

Second verse in "f", in line 3 there is a caesura

Richer dust because it is where an English soldier died

Personification of dust

Reference to the English countryside → English / England = is a polyptoton (repetition of words that share the same root)

The sestet is more metaphysical

Eternal life is a sort of after life

This is an idealistic poem

Dulce et Decorum est - Wilfred Owen

The title is a partial quotation of the Latin poem of Horace (Orazio) → however the quotation is ironic, there is nothing good about war is the message

There are rhymes (so no free verses) → but the verses are iambic pentameters (or maybe soldier in this one not? ask)

4 stanzas

First one sets the scene

"Like old beggars" is a simile → he talks about a group of soldiers → unheroic representation

"Like hags" (old women) →another simile

"Sludge" = mud

Verse 3 and 4 →they have gone over the top, they attacked →now they return to their trenches

"Limped on " = zoppicare

Line 6 →diacope of "all"

In the second one, a gas attack is described

One was not quick enough to wear the mask

"Under a green sea" →simile →the gas turned the air green →he sees his comrade dying

Stanza 3 is about the trauma, that seeing his comrade dying has created in the writer
Consonance of "s", first line

Stanza 4 conveys the message of the whole poem

"Like a devil" →simile, his fate is like the one of a devil

Message is that pro war propaganda should not exist →it convinces young men to leave for the front

The view of line 1 and the one of "my friend" in line 9 make reference to Jessie Pope, a (singoistic = patriotic) poetess and journalist

She became famous during the war for writing several pro war poems and articles on British newspapers, that wanted to convince young British men to go to war

This poem had another title: "To a certain poetess" →then it was changed, but because of this change some scholars believe that "my friend" and "you" can be referred to members of the propaganda system in general

Owen had a similar but different story to Brooke →he was a volunteer too, but then he developed an antiwar position

He got a severe form of shell-shock →he was hospitalized at Craiglockhart hospital (Scottish hospital where shell shocks were sent) →after some months of treatment, they sent him to the front

He died only one week before the end of the war

1920s - 1930s in England

These years have 3 labels:

- the interwar years →purely historical

- the age of anxiety →intellectual atmosphere characterizing these years
- anglo-american modernism →most relevant cultural movement that developed during this period

The UK and US lived these years in very different ways for ? it was tuff →british economy started to have economic problems, and during the inter war years the british empire started collapsing

The real collapse happened after the WWII, but slowly starts here →in 1921 the british empire lost Ireland, its nearest colony →Eire, the Republic of Ireland was established

Northern Ireland remains part of the UK

Now the so known "irish troubles" (1921 - 1994) begin →in 1994 a truce was signed (not a peace treaty)

The irish troubles consisted in a civil war between northern irish catholics and northern irish anglicans →catholics wanted northern ireland to become part of the Eire, while anglicans wanted to remain part of the UK

Many riots and terroristic attacks →that happened in the UK too

The organization that organized these attacks was the I.R.A →irish republic army (catholic terroristic org.), that fought for making northern ireland part of Eire

In the 1930s, according to the Statute of Westminster, some colonies were given the state of "dominions" →not independent, but could be more autonomous →the UK was not able to control its empire with an iron fist anymore →they had to make some concessions

This does not happen however with India →after the WWII, with the process of decolonization, the english empire got dismantled

The 1920s - 1930s

In the USA the 1920s were a decade of prosperity (in UK they were hard times) → these years are known as "the roaring twenties"

A novel which reflects on the excess of this age is "The Great Gatsby" by Fitzgerald → the main characters are young rich people, but they are unable to reach happiness because they have to go through personal tragedies

These years ended in 1929 with the Wall Street crisis → so 1930s were hard times, until 1935 with the New Deal

But age of anxiety → ones mean the intellectual atmosphere that characterizes these years in the USA → most American intellectuals felt anxiety, due to the loss of certainties

That collective loss were caused by:

- the great war → it was a collective traumatic experience:
 - 10 million people died, mainly soldiers but also many civilians
 - it showed how cruel humans can be
 - shows how progress can be detrimental and devastating, if not controlled by ethics
- revolutionary theories → either elaborated in those years, or elaborated before but became accepted in the 20s and 30s → they contradicted many ideals those intellectuals believed in:
 - Darwin's theory → after WWI became actually accepted → it denies years of biblical education, and humans are not privileged creatures
 - Freud's theory → in particular his three part model of the human psyche → most of the psyche is dark and unexplored:
 - * id: unconscious, impulsive
 - * ego: the rational side
 - * super ego: moral norms humans are taught to live in society
 - Einstein's theory → theory of relativity, which made the concepts of time and space relative and not absolute
 - Bergson's theory → he elaborates a theory of time, according to which there are two types of time:
 - * external objective time, measured by clocks
 - * psychological, subjective time → called duration

- Frazer's theory →he is an anthropologist (science that originated in the second part of the 19th century, and studies human societies all around the world) →in particular primitive societies →in "The Golden Bough" he writes about his studies regarding some african societies, and says that even if they are primitive, these societies are complex and articulated = discovery clashes with imperialism →now some intellectuals (modernists) got interested in the culture of these populations

The second coming - William Butler Yeats

He is a modernist irish poet

By reading this poem, we can understand what it meant to be an intellectual during the age of anxiety

This poem was written in 1919 →the war had just finished and the europeans economies were devastated, + there the russian revolution just happened

Between 1919 and 1921 there was a civil war in Ireland, which concluded with the creation of the Free Republic of Ireland →then another one started in northern ireland ??

Yeats elaborated a personal theory of history →he believed that human history was divided into cycles lasting 2000 years each

He also gave a graphic representation of this cycles →each one has the shape of gyre

Two stanzas →the first one is objective (it presents a description of the world at the time) and shorter →the second subjective because it is about a vision of the future and longer

He was leaving in 1919, ending of the cycle that started with Christ's birth →the falcon cannot hear the falconer stands for this and is a metaphore →this means that the cycle is about to finish

Turning →is a diacope

Falcon and falconer is a polyptoton

Mere anarchy →there is not a political orientation in that world

The tide →refernce of the great world war

The world functions the other way around

There is a vision about the future, that lyrical eye has

The first coming was the birth of christ, now the new cycle begins with a second coming →it has not happened yet, he has a vision about the future

As the sun in the desert →simile

The new creature is monstrous one, a sphinx-like creature

Rocking cradle = culla ondeggiante

Jesus was born in Bethlem →the creature is anit-christ

The message is that the historical cycle is finishing, and a new one is going to start
→and nightmarish one

Yeats was an irish independentits →he also wrote political poems

Anglo modernism

Definition: *A cultural movement developing in the ENglish-speaking contries starting to emerge at the end of the 19th century, more clearly after the Great War, as a reaction against the wrongs of its age with its puritanical, authoritative, imperialistic and materialistic attitude. Modernism likewise reacted against the art of the past, considere as unable to represent and understand the modern world*

High modernism is the one that was born after the WWI

Modernist artists tried to find new ways to understand reality

The one before WWI went against past art →after they recognize the value of the art of the past, but this art has to be adapted

Angloamerican modernism

High modernism →early has a different behaviour towards tradition

Vorticism →resembles futurism Association of ideas

Ulysis is a rewriting of the odysse of Omer in a modern way

Leopold Bloom is a modern Ulysis

He is married to Molly (modern Penelope) →her main feature is being faithful →but she is not faithful to Leopold

Telemachus is his son, but not with Molly

Modernists:

- Joyce
- Virginia Woolf

1922 annus mirabilis

Waste land is a long narrative poem